GATORBAIT

MAGAZINE · FRIDAY PREGAME

FLORIDA AT NO. 7 TEXAS



NO. 9 TRAMELL JONES JR. · IN LINE FOR HIS FIRST START. PHILO QUESTIONABLE (SHOULDER).

PHOTO: CHRIS SPEARS, GATORBAIT MEDIA

WHO'S QB1 IN AUSTIN?

BUDDY MARTIN'S COVER STORY · SATURDAY · NOON ET · ABC

GATORBAITMEDIA.COM

THE GAME

UNRANKED
FLORIDA
4-2 · 2-2 SEC

AT

NO. 7
TEXAS
4-1 · 1-1 SEC

Saturday, Oct. 17 · noon ET · ABC
Darrell K Royal-Texas Memorial Stadium, Austin. Sold out

Sunny, 0% rain; 59° at 11 a.m. CT kickoff, 68° by 3 p.m.; NNE wind 10 mph, gusts to 30 (NWS, Oct. 15)

LINE	TOTAL	SERIES	ESPN MATCHUP PREDICTOR
Texas -11.5	51.5	UF trails 1-3-1	Florida 12.5%

ESPN game summary and pickcenter (DraftKings), Oct. 15. Kickoff and TV also on TexasLonghorns.com game center and FloridaGators.com schedule. Forecast: NWS Austin/San Antonio, Oct. 15.

FOUR KEYS

1. Arch Manning vs. the No. 131 pass defense

Florida allows 268.7 passing yards a game, which ESPN ranks 131st nationally, and 29.0 points a game (113th). Arch Manning is 92 of 146 for 1,122 yards, 10 touchdowns and five interceptions, and Texas averages 237.0 passing yards a game. Texas' own defense gives up 168.4 through the air.

2. Jadan Baugh and the run game vs. a Texas D that allows 96.0

Florida runs for 200.3 yards a game at 5.0 a carry, and Jadan Baugh has 110 carries for 672 yards and 12 touchdowns. Texas allows 96.0 rushing yards a game (ESPN rank 19th), 264.4 total yards (12th) and 16.0 points (21st). Texas runs for 142.2 at 3.7 a carry; Hollywood Smothers leads with 237 yards on 53 carries.

3. Turnovers and sacks

Florida is plus-3 in turnover margin with 10 takeaways and seven giveaways; Texas is plus-1 with eight and seven. Manning has thrown five interceptions, and Texas has taken 12 sacks in five games to Florida's eight in six. On defense Florida has 17 sacks, Jayden Woods leading with 4.5, and Texas has 18, Colin Simmons leading with 9.5.

4. Third downs

Texas' defense has held opponents to 30.4% on third down (21 of 69); Florida's has allowed 46.2% (43 of 93). On offense the teams are close: Florida converts 45.2% (33 of 73) and Texas 44.6% (33 of 74).

ESPN 2026 team statistics, national ranks and game-summary leaders, Oct. 15 (Florida six games, Texas five)

TALE OF THE TAPE

Season, per game: Florida through six games, Texas through five

	FLORIDA	TEXAS
Points scored	41.7	31.4
Total yards	473.8	379.2
Rushing yards	200.3	142.2
Yards a carry	5	3.7
Passing yards	273.5	237
Points allowed	29	16
Rush yards allowed	124.3	96
Pass yards allowed	268.7	168.4
Third down %	45.2	44.6
Opp. third down %	46.2	30.4
Possession (minutes)	32.2	31.1

ESPN 2026 team statistics, Oct. 15 (possession minutes figured from ESPN's season possession seconds divided by games played)

THE SERIES

FIVE MEETINGS, ONE GATOR WIN

Texas leads 3-1-1 in five meetings that began with a 7-7 tie in Austin on Oct. 25, 1924. Florida's only win is the latest: 29-21 in Gainesville on Oct. 4, 2025. Texas won 49-17 in Austin on Nov. 9, 2024, and Florida is 0-2-1 in Austin.

AVAILABILITY

ESPN lists no injuries for either team as of Thursday, Oct. 15. The official SEC availability report posts Friday on FloridaGators.com.

BY THE NUMBERS

Six figures that frame Saturday

-11.5

TEXAS, THE LINE

Total 51.5. DraftKings line via ESPN pickcenter, Oct. 15.

87.5%

ESPN PREDICTOR, TEXAS

Florida at 12.5% in the ESPN matchup predictor.

1-3-1

FLORIDA IN THE SERIES

Last meeting: Florida 29-21 in Gainesville, Oct. 4, 2025.

672

BAUGH RUSHING YARDS

Jadan Baugh: 110 carries, 12 touchdowns; Florida runs for 200.3 a game at 5.0 a carry.

131st

FLORIDA PASS DEFENSE

268.7 passing yards allowed a game, 131st nationally. Texas throws for 237.0.

16.0

TEXAS POINTS ALLOWED

Texas allows 16.0 points a game, 21st nationally; Florida scores 41.7.

ESPN game summary and pickcenter (event 401856724), ESPN 2026 team statistics and national ranks, Oct. 15; FloridaGators.com series history.

WHAT WE'RE WATCHING

GatorBait Media writers, in their own words

> It will depend a lot upon the composure of the new starting quarterback, Tramell Jones Jr., who's a promising talent but drew the short straw for his first college start: in Austin, Texas, against a team that two weeks ago was ranked No. 1 in the nation.
>
> **BUDDY MARTIN**

> Can the Florida offensive line win enough battles to score 30?
>
> **EDDIE GILLEY**

Writers' lines filed by email, Oct. 16; AP Top 25 rank via ESPN (Texas No. 1 in the Oct. 5 poll, No. 7 in the Oct. 11 poll)

THE DESK · SATURDAY MATH

TWO SETS OF NUMBERS, ONE POINT SPREAD

The market says Texas by 11.5. The season averages say something closer. Both can be true, and the gap between them is Saturday's story.

BY THE GATORBAIT MEDIA DESK

> **"THE AVERAGES SAY CLOSE. THE LINE SAYS IT ISN'T."**

POINTS A GAME, SEASON AVERAGES



Texas is favored by 11.5 at noon ET on Saturday, and the total is 51.5. Do the arithmetic and the market is picturing something near Texas 31.5, Florida 20.

Now put the season averages side by side. Florida scores 41.7 points a game. Texas allows 16.0. Texas scores 31.4. Florida allows 29.0. Split each matchup down the middle and you land at about 29 for Florida and 30 for Texas. That is not a prediction. It is a reminder that the line and the stats are answering different questions. The line knows about a road trip and a quarterback who may be making his first start. The averages do not.

Where the line has a case: Florida's pass defense gives up 268.7 yards a game, 131st nationally, and Arch Manning is 92 of 146 for 1,122 yards with 10 touchdowns and five interceptions. Texas throws for 237.0 a game. That is the matchup the 11.5 is built on.

Where Florida has one: the ground. The Gators run for 200.3 yards a game at 5.0 a carry, and Jadan Baugh has 672 yards and 12 touchdowns on 110 carries. Texas allows 96.0 rushing yards a game, 19th nationally. One of those numbers moves on Saturday.

Two smaller figures decide how close the game stays. Texas holds opponents to 30.4% on third down, 21 of 69. Florida allows 46.2%, 43 of 93. On offense the teams are almost even: 45.2% for Florida, 44.6% for Texas. Add the turnover margin, plus-3 for Florida and plus-1 for Texas, and the path to a close game runs through who finishes drives.

History adds a note of caution. Florida is 0-2-1 in Austin, and its only win in five meetings came last October in Gainesville, 29-21.

The averages say close. The line says it isn't. Noon will settle it.

Source: ESPN game summary and pickcenter (event 401856724), ESPN 2026 team statistics and national ranks, Oct. 15 (Florida six games, Texas five); FloridaGators.com series history. The implied score is figured from the 11.5-point spread and 51.5 total. The split-the-middle figures are simple averages of the per-game numbers shown.

COVER STORY · BUDDY MARTIN

QB1 PHILO HURT. QB2 JONES TO START? EXPLAINED BY THAT GREAT FOOTBALL MIND TED LASSO

BY BUDDY MARTIN Oct. 15, 2026



Photo by Chris Spears, GatorBait Media

> **"HE DOESN'T MIND HIS PLAYERS ENJOYING SUCCESS. HE JUST DOESN'T WANT THEM MOVING INTO IT AND BUYING FURNITURE."**



Photo by Chris Spears, GatorBait Media

Philo's hurt. Jones might start. Texas is waiting.

So Buddy Martin called in the two greatest minds he knows, Albert Einstein and Ted Lasso, to explain Jon Sumrall's reverse thermostat, why calm is not surrender, and why Gator fans might not be crazy for believing.

Members, the biscuits are inside.

Einstein had relativity. Ted Lasso has biscuits. And an amazing attitude. So does Tramell Jones.

This may be an emergency call for that great football mind Ted Lasso.

Starting Gator quarterback Aaron Philo is injured and won't start. Backup quarterback Tramell Jones could get the nod. The orange and blue house looks like it's about to burn down. What would Ted Lasso do?

"Turn up the thermostat!" No doubt.

"Is it ideal? No. But ideal's like a perfect meatloaf — sounds nice, rarely happens," Ted would probably say. "You go to war with the quarterback you got, not the quarterback you wish you had. And Jonesy? Jonesy's gonna be just fine. Be a goldfish, everybody."

Tramell Jones has been pure gold — don't know about the fish part.

My diehard Gator friend John texted me with a question as soon as we heard about the questionable status of Aaron Philo and the possible start of Tramell Jones. "Am I crazy for thinking that Florida might beat Texas?"

I gave him the Lasso quote.

"I like it!" said John.

See, already Ted has had a positive impact.

I mean, what else we got to hang our hats on?

I'll go with Einstein and Lasso.

Ted would understand.

In an imaginary meeting of these great minds — not an actual Lasso quotation — Ted might explain it this way to Sumrall:

"Jon, when they're feeling ten feet tall, you remind 'em to duck through the doorway. When they're feeling two feet tall, you help 'em reach the doorknob."

Then he might suggest decaf.

Einstein, meanwhile, could work on the larger mystery: how a coach can lower his voice and have people conclude he has lost his fire.

Around football, we sometimes confuse volume with conviction. A man screaming into a headset must care deeply. A man speaking calmly must be checking property listings.

Sumrall says he's not changing his commitment. He's changing his delivery.

That's a distinction worth hearing, even if he doesn't holler it.

There's coaching how you feel, and there's coaching what your players need. Those aren't always the same thing. Especially when you're dealing with a young team that already knows it hasn't been very good.

You can point out the burning building without pulling the fire alarm every thirty seconds.

Lasso's contribution to this discussion is his opposition to two buttons: "panic" and "snooze."

A useful operating manual.

When everybody else is applauding, Sumrall supplies the alarm clock. When everybody else is panicking, he tries to steady the room.

Neither approach guarantees a first down. But both make more sense than letting the coach's mood become another opponent.

Of course, after two straight losses, Florida fans aren't conducting a seminar on emotional intelligence.

They'd like to win a football game.

They're open to relativity, positive reinforcement and homemade biscuits, provided somebody blocks.

That doesn't make them unreasonable. It makes them football fans.

Einstein would have had trouble with them, too, particularly if he'd opened a press conference by saying he needed to study the film.

Jones has already endured a major disappointment when he didn't win the job.

The first question asked about Tramell's reaction to falling short in the competition, he responded to admirably.

"Definitely disappointed, but after the decision, I had two choices to make: I could either lay my head down, shy away from the opportunity. "Teammates would see me down. That's not the kind of energy you want to hold," Jones Jr. said.

"Or option two: I can keep competing, I can keep working, I can keep getting better, I can keep developing in the offense.

"That's exactly what I'm going to do."

He's a Lasso natural!

When considering the great thinkers, you naturally start with Einstein, work your way through the philosophers and eventually arrive at Ted Lasso.

Different hair. Same search for answers.

Einstein wanted to explain the universe. Lasso wanted to explain people. Ted may have drawn the tougher assignment. The universe doesn't call a radio show after losing two straight.

Which brings us to Sumrall.

Florida's football coach likes to quote Lasso, placing him in a distinguished intellectual tradition: men trying to figure out why other men do things they were specifically told not to do.

Einstein had a blackboard. Lasso had a locker room and a grease board. Sumrall has a young football team and a fan base that would appreciate somebody solving for W.

Sumrall recently explained a coaching philosophy that sounds backward until you give it a minute.

"When things are going good for our guys: I'm probably more of a maniac on everybody. When things aren't going good, I have to figure out how to calm down because we are still young, maybe at times immature, emotional bunch."

There it is. The Sumrall Theory of Relativity.

His temperature is relative to theirs.

When his players are feeling wonderful, he supplies a few reasons not to.

When they're feeling miserable, he figures the public has that assignment covered.

Call it a reverse thermostat.

"Great news," Lasso might postulate. "Tramell will be great. Wait until you see him spin it!"

Most of us turn up the heat when we're cold. Sumrall turns up the heat when everybody's getting comfortable.

He doesn't mind his players enjoying success. He just doesn't want them moving into it and buying furniture.

Still, Sumrall's explanation deserves something better than an automatic verdict that calm means surrender.

Sometimes a team needs a cattle prod. Sometimes it needs a steadying hand. The trick is knowing which one to bring to practice.

Ted Lasso would probably call that understanding people.

Einstein might call it an intriguing theory.

Florida fans will call it brilliant the minute it starts to work.

A low bar, but we'll take it.

Watch: "Florida QB Watch: Philo or Jones?" on The Buddy Martin Show

PHILO'S INJURY COULD GIVE TRAMELL JONES JR. HIS OPENING

BY FRANZ BEARD Oct. 14, 2026



Photo by Chris Spears, GatorBait Media

Aaron Philo, No. 12, at left, and Tramell Jones Jr., No. 9, at right, on Florida's sideline against South Carolina on Oct. 10, 2026. Photo by Chris Spears, GatorBait Media.

On June 2, 1925, Wally Pipp suffered what has become known as the most famous headache in history. Legend has it that Pipp asked for the day off because of a raging headache, so New York Yankees manager Miller Huggins replaced him in the starting lineup with Lou Gehrig, who went 3-for-5 against the Washington Senators.

It was years before Gehrig relinquished his job as the Yankees' first baseman (2,130 consecutive games played). Pipp was sold to Cincinnati in 1926.

When it comes to University of Florida football, there have been a couple of notable injuries in recent years.

In 2019, Feleipe Franks dislocated his ankle at Kentucky with the Gators trailing 21-10 late in the third quarter. Kyle Trask led the Gators to a stunning comeback for a 29-21 UF win and never looked back. He started the rest of the year and in 2020 finished fourth in Heisman Trophy voting.

In 2024, Graham Mertz had the Gators teetering on the verge of an upset of Tennessee in Knoxville when he tore an ACL. Freshman DJ Lagway filled in the rest of the way as the Gators dropped a 23-17 decision to the Vols, but Lagway would go on to lead the Gators to an 8-5 record, their only winning record other than the Trask-led Gators 8-4 mark in 2020 during the six seasons from 2020 through 2025.

It is unfortunate, but so often one man's injury is another man's opportunity. It was reported Wednesday that Florida (4-2, 2-2 SEC) starting quarterback Aaron Philo's availability is uncertain for Saturday's game in Austin against No. 7 Texas (4-1, 1-1 SEC). If Philo is unable to answer the bell against Texas (noon ET, ABC), Tramell Jones Jr. will be the starter. Jones is next in line as the Gators prep for the Longhorns.

The Gainesville Sun reported that Philo suffered a shoulder injury in the Gators' 38-19 loss to South Carolina, a game that was finished by sophomore Jones. There has been no indication if it was Philo's right (throwing) or left shoulder, which could be the deciding factor in whether or not he is fit to play.

If Philo is a no-go and Jones plays very well, either leading the Gators to what would be a stunning upset or a white-knuckle finish, would Sumrall abide by that unwritten football rule that you don't lose your starting job because of an injury or would he roll the dice and go with Jones against Georgia in two weeks?

The old football rule sounds very good and reeks of loyalty but doesn't necessarily fly in this modern age when coaches are paid millions. There aren't that many seven-figure jobs to be had, so if a replacement QB steps in and has a hot hand, is he relegated back to the bench when the injured player is healthy again?

Sumrall has said more than once that he believes the Gators can win with either Philo or Jones at quarterback, but certainly experience favors Philo, who has started all six games at UF including two on the road in SEC play (Auburn and Missouri).

Jones has played in seven games, all of them off the bench. His career stats are 44-for-64 passing (68.75 percent) for 443 yards (6.92 yards per attempt) with four touchdown passes and two interceptions. In his last two SEC games, Jones is 11-13 for 126 yards with one TD and one interception.

COUNTDOWN TO FIRING DAY: OCTOBER 15, 2026 EDITION

EXTINCT SPECIES LIST

Keep an eye on what happens with Rutgers at Maryland and Florida State at Miami.

ON LIFE SUPPORT

Mike Norvell, Florida State: The Seminoles led Louisville 14-0 in the first quarter, then lost the next three quarters 44-6. That was bad. What promises to happen this weekend at Miami will be even worse. The boosters want Norvell gone, but the buyout remains a major obstacle. That leaves two choices: Keep Norvell another year (bad) or convince Jimbo to coach for $1 million to $2 million for the next five years (bad idea, but better than keeping him).

Dave Doeren, North Carolina State: The next six games are actually winnable but anything more than 3-3 or 4-2 would be a miracle. He has won more than he's lost but the faithful want more than bowl games in scenic, exotic locales like Shreveport. He will be gone with a losing season and could be gone with a break-even record.

Mike Locksley, Maryland: If the Turtles figure out a way to lose to Rutgers this weekend, Locks could be the first coaching domino to fall. Maryland has given up 182 points during its four-game skid. Only Saturday's game with Rutgers looks remotely winnable. Maryland is a former ACC school trying to compete in the Big Ten and it's just not working out. Locksley's buyout is cheap comparatively speaking.

Greg Schiano, Rutgers: A 1-6 record the rest of the way would be a small miracle. The one chance is Saturday at Maryland. This could be a loser gets voted off the island kind of game. The only thing that will stand in the way of Schiano getting pink-slipped is the buyout - which is roughly $18.5 million after the 2026 season.

Bill O'Brien, Boston College: There are a couple of saving graces working in O'Brien's favor. First off, BC might spend less on football than any power conference team, so the fact he has the Eagles competitive could help him keep his job at least one more year. Second, the Eagles are competitive. They've lost two straight to Virginia Tech and SMU by a combined 16 points. Virginia Tech had to rally for two fourth quarter touchdowns to win. If any of the remaining teams other than Notre Dame and Miami blows the Eagles out, however, it could be the end of the line for O'Brien.

Joe Moorhead, Akron: The Zips are 1-5, going absolutely nowhere. He's 14-40 for his career at Akron. He's lasted this long because Akron really doesn't have the money to go through the firing and hiring process even though Moorhead works very cheap. Miami (Ohio) should handle the Zips easily this week but the admin is unlikely to do anything until season's end.

ENDANGERED SPECIES LIST

Steve Sarkisian, Texas: The Longhorns are 4-1, formerly ranked No. 1. The Aggies await in the season finale. Anything less than 10-2 and Sark's job could be on the line. The buyout won't faze the boosters. Only God has more money than the Longhorns.

Shane Beamer, South Carolina: He had one foot out the door last Saturday morning. By Saturday evening, he was off life support and moved to the Endangered Species List. The win over Florida is only a temporary reprieve. Now Beamer has to figure out a way to win four of the next six starting with Tennessee on Oct. 24 in Columbia.

Bill Belichick, North Carolina: Beating Pitt on the road last week renewed hope among the faithful that perhaps Belichick can make the Tar Heels relevant on the national stage. The Heels are 3-2 this year and with the exception of Miami, there isn't a game on the remaining schedule that UNC can't win. All the same, he's got to get the Tar Heels bowl eligible.

Deion Sanders, Colorado: Three straight losses and now Utah and Okie State back-to-back. The Buffs are 2-3 and will struggle to get to six wins. Six will buy another year. Five and things get really dicey.

Dave Aranda, Baylor: The Bears are 4-1 and could be 8-1 before closing out the season with the (at) BYU, Texas Tech, (at) Houston gauntlet. Seven wins and Aranda's off the hook. Eight or nine and he gets a contract extension.

Lincoln Riley, Southern Cal: The Trojans are 6-1 so why is Riley in any kind of trouble. Well, it has everything to do with no championships since he came to LA from Oklahoma. His tenure this year will be judged by what he does in games against Ohio State, Indiana and UCLA.

Butch Jones, Arkansas State: He's 2-4 but Jones has made a habit of winning more than he loses in the second half of the season. He probably won't get canned this year unless the Red Wolves go completely in the tank, but if he doesn't get to six wins in the regular season his seat will be very hot to start 2027.

Brent Venables, Oklahoma: The win over Texas was a shocker. The next three games - Kentucky, (at) Mississippi State and South Carolina - are must win games. A 6-2 record heading into November will have the Sooners in line for a CFP at-large.

Dabo Swinney, Clemson: The Tigers are 3-2, but blessed with seven remaining games that are all very winnable. Clemson really isn't 10 wins good, but the ACC is that bad this year.

Fran Brown, Syracuse: The schedule is brutal and there aren't many potential wins to be had. The Orange are 2-3 and heading for 3-9 or 4-8. Brown won't get fired this year, but he will be on the hot seat next year.

THE BIG PICTURE · BUDDY MARTIN

IS THE SEC UNDERGOING A DRAIN OF EXCELLENCE?

Parody or parity? The SEC hasn't lost excellence so much as its monopoly on it, and a 24-team playoff threatens to make the difference matter less.

BY BUDDY MARTIN Oct. 16, 2026



Graphic: GatorBait Media

> **"THERE SHOULD BE ROOM IN COLLEGE FOOTBALL FOR A SEASON TO MEAN SOMETHING OTHER THAN 'ADVANCED' OR 'ELIMINATED.'"**

They have thrown out the bathwater and now they're coming for the baby!

Apparently, there is nothing sacred left about college football, or the SEC.

That's the way one side looks at it. The other side, led by the Matt Barries of the world, thinks we are in the throes of the "greatest football" weeks in history.

Me, I worry that the scavengers have come for what's left of college football.

As Nick Saban has said, it used to be more important for the Southern teams to win the SEC than the national championship.

The preservation of that tradition seems more important than the money. But then there is this:

ESPN reported that replacing the SEC championship game alone required accounting for an event generating roughly $80 million to $100 million.

I have generally found that when they say "it's not about the money," it is, indeed, about the money.

I'm not buying that this playoff on steroids is good for all of college football. Once they started trying to fix college football, they broke it worse.

Does this new 24-team playoff not have the fingerprints of the Big Ten all over it? Well, you betcha, Tony Petitti! But your side has been holding serve now for three years, so I guess it's losers walk.

A parody is a humorous or satirical imitation of a specific work, author or style, created to mock, critique or comment on the original. Sometimes this whole thing feels like a mockery.

My take: The SEC hasn't lost excellence. It has lost some of its monopoly on excellence, and a 24-team playoff threatens to make the distinction between "excellent" and "merely pretty good" matter less. Those are related problems, but they aren't the same problem.

One important clarification on recent news: ESPN reports that a deal for a 24-team playoff beginning in 2027 is nearing completion, pending final approvals. It is not yet a finalized format. The expected changes include eliminating Power Four championship games and starting the season a week earlier.

Have we lost our respect and reverence for tradition?

WHAT'S WRONG WITH THE SEC?

First, the decline at the very top is real, not merely nostalgia for when every September came with an Alabama national championship reservation.

Entering this season, the SEC had gone three consecutive seasons without winning a national championship, or even putting a team in the championship game. That followed a stretch of 13 national titles in 17 seasons. Against that standard, a good conference can look like a fallen empire.

But I would separate three things:

- A conference with several good teams.
- A conference with one or two genuinely great teams.
- A conference whose reputation makes us assume those great teams must be there.

The SEC built its reputation by delivering the second. Sometimes we now give it credit for the second merely because it has the first.

This season's evidence doesn't suggest excellence has vanished entirely. The Athletic's Oct. 11 assessment had Georgia at 6-0, followed by Alabama at 5-1 and Texas at 4-1, with Georgia clearly favored in its conference-title projections. That looks more like an uneven league with a leading contender than a league devoid of quality.

WHY DON'T MORE TEAMS LOOK GREAT?

Talent is harder to stockpile. NIL and transfer freedom have loosened the traditional powers' grip on recruiting and roster retention. ESPN's examination of the SEC's championship drought and Yahoo's recent assessment of conference parity both identify that redistribution as an important explanation.

It is harder to build an overwhelming machine when the players who would once have supplied its second wave can find money and playing time elsewhere. That can improve competition without improving the best team. More competitive Saturdays and fewer dominant teams can coexist.

THE SCHEDULE COMPLICATES THE PICTURE

The SEC's nine-game conference schedule arrived this season, adding another league opponent to the annual test. That makes records harder to compare with those from the eight-game era.

But "we beat each other up" cannot become a permanent exemption from scrutiny. A close conference game might mean two excellent teams collided. It might also mean neither could take control. Conference membership doesn't settle that argument; performance does.

WE SOMETIMES CONFUSE PARITY WITH QUALITY

Parity tells us the teams are closer together. It does not tell us how high the ceiling is. Is everybody capable of beating somebody, or is somebody capable of beating everybody?

WOULD 24 TEAMS DIMINISH EXCELLENCE FURTHER?

It would diminish the requirement for sustained excellence more than excellence itself. An outstanding team would still be outstanding. But the system would ask fewer teams to demonstrate that quality week after week before granting them a championship opportunity.

The proposed field under discussion includes 19 at-large selections, the four Power Four conference champions as determined by their leagues, and the highest-ranked Group of Six team. Final details remain unannounced.

That creates several concerns.

1. MORE CHANCES TO RECOVER MEAN FEWER OCCASIONS WHEN LOSING IS DECISIVE

There is a legitimate benefit: More fan bases would have meaningful postseason stakes later in the season.

But there is a cost at the top. If a contender can absorb another defeat without seriously endangering qualification, that defeat carries less championship consequence. Seeding can preserve incentives; it cannot completely reproduce the jeopardy of elimination.

The important distinction is between making more games relevant to the bracket and making the biggest games more consequential. Expansion can accomplish the first while weakening the second.

My concern is what follows culturally: Programs could sell a playoff appearance as evidence of excellence when it might represent a respectable season rather than an exceptional one. Conversely, some schools could begin treating otherwise respectable seasons as failures simply because they missed an enlarged field. More participation does not necessarily produce a more sensible definition of success.

2. LOSING CONFERENCE CHAMPIONSHIP GAMES WOULD REMOVE A DISTINCT ACHIEVEMENT

Under the deal ESPN describes, Power Four championship games are expected to disappear, although leagues would still determine champions for playoff qualification.

Ugh!

A conference championship ought to have meaning beyond its usefulness in arranging the national bracket. My objection isn't that the existing title games are perfect. It's that eliminating them makes the sport even more exclusively about one postseason tournament.

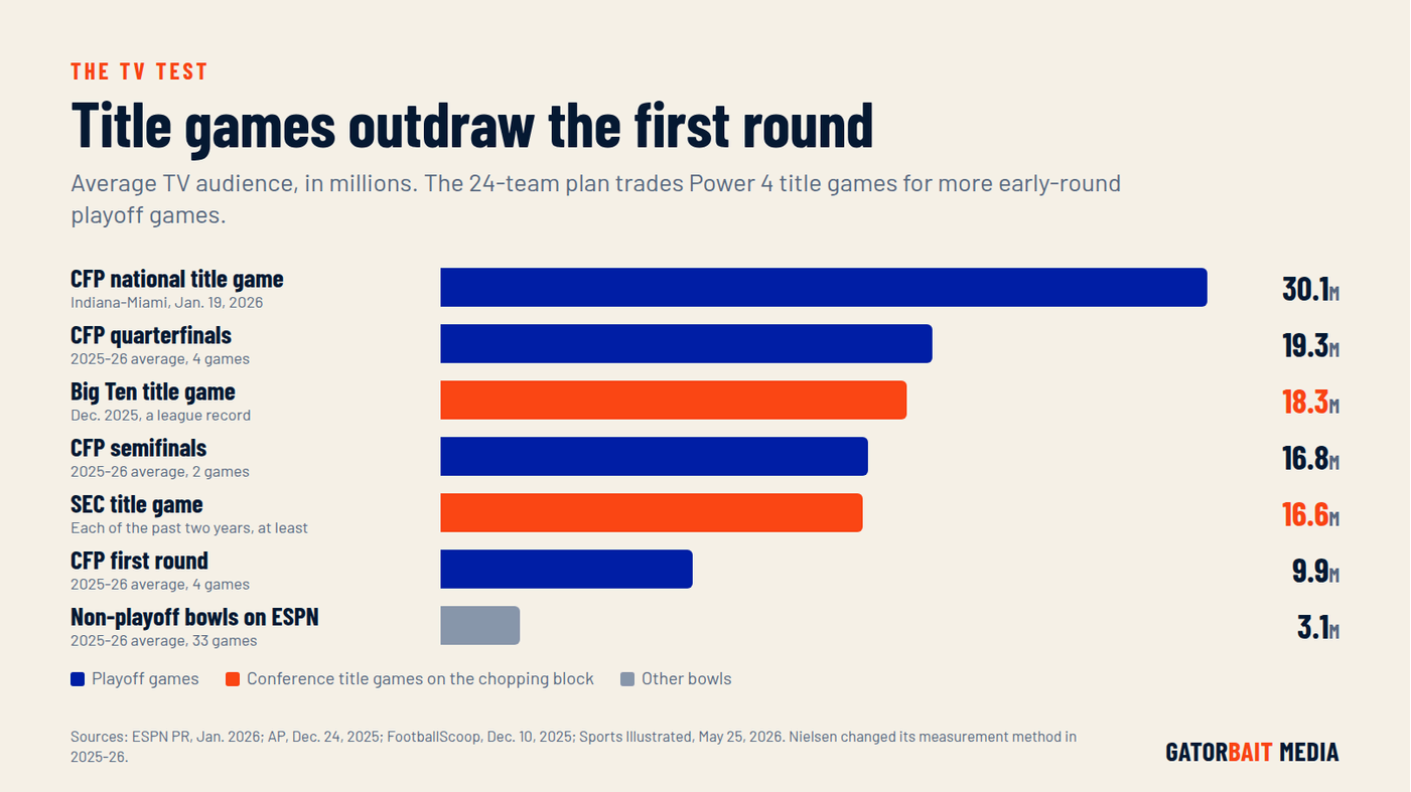
There should be room in college football for a season to mean something other than "advanced" or "eliminated."

3. THE STRONGEST ARGUMENT AGAINST EXPANSION ISN'T THAT EVERY UNDERDOG WILL LOSE

Some lower seeds would win. An upset would be exciting. Neither point answers whether 24 is the right number.

The better question is: What problem does doubling the field solve that is important enough to justify changing the value of the regular season?

The financial incentive is substantial. During negotiations, ESPN reported that replacing the SEC championship game alone required accounting for an event generating roughly $80 million to $100 million. Revenue and compensation for lost championship games were central to the SEC's position.



Title games outdraw the first round: average TV audiences for the playoff rounds and the conference title games a 24-team plan would drop. Graphic: GatorBait Media

That doesn't automatically make expansion wrong. But it does mean "better championship competition" and "more valuable television inventory" should not be treated as interchangeable goals.

The SEC's challenge is to produce teams that restore its competitive authority. Expanding the playoff could give the conference more places to put teams without answering whether those teams are truly exceptional.

That's the danger: not that excellence disappears, but that college football becomes less demanding about who gets to claim it.

SATURDAY IN THE SEC: THE SOOTHSAYER'S PICKS

Picks by Franz Beard, from The Soothsayer. Kickoffs and TV: ESPN scoreboard. All times ET. Florida's line from ESPN.

TIME (ET)	GAME	TV	LINE
Noon	**Florida (4-2) at No. 7 Texas (4-1)** Texas by three TDs or more	**ABC**	**TEX -11.5 · O/U 51.5**
Noon	No. 16 Mississippi State (4-1) at No. 22 LSU (4-2)	ESPN/Disney+	
1 p.m.	The Citadel (2-4) at Texas A&M (3-3)	SECN+	
3:30 p.m.	Auburn (3-2) at No. 1 Georgia (6-0)	ESPN	
3:30 p.m.	No. 6 Alabama (5-1) at No. 14 Tennessee (5-1) Brace for a white-knuckle finish	ABC	
3:30 p.m.	No. 13 Missouri (5-1) at No. 9 Ole Miss (4-1) Heart says Mizzou; mind says Rebels	SEC Network	
7 p.m.	Arkansas (2-4) at Vanderbilt (3-3)	ESPN2	
7:30 p.m.	No. 15 Kentucky (5-1) at Oklahoma (3-2)	SEC Network	

Kickoffs, TV, records and rankings: ESPN SEC scoreboard for Oct. 17, checked against the AP Top 25 (Week 7) and ESPN SEC standings, Oct. 15. Florida-Texas line and total: ESPN pickcenter (DraftKings), Oct. 15. Picks: Franz Beard, The Soothsayer, Oct. 16.

HOW TO WATCH

KICKOFF	Saturday, Oct. 17, noon ET (11 a.m. CT)
TV	ABC
STREAM	ESPN app, with a TV-provider login
RADIO	ESPN Radio (national feed). Gator IMG Sports Network details not yet confirmed
WHERE	Darrell K Royal-Texas Memorial Stadium, Austin. Sold out

Sources: ESPN broadcast listing and game summary; TexasLonghorns.com game center (11 a.m. CT, ABC, sold out); FloridaGators.com schedule (noon ET)

FRANZ BEARD · THE SOOTHSAYER

THE SOOTHSAYER: TEXAS BIG UNLESS THE UF DEFENSE FINDS AN EXORCIST

BY FRANZ BEARD Oct. 16, 2026



Photo by Chris Spears, GatorBait Media

"Out in the ocean, a rope is put around a man's neck. The other end of the rope is attached to an old jukebox and it is thrown overboard. The man invariably follows." – From "The Gang That Couldn't Shoot Straight," a novel by Jimmy Breslin.

This is what the Florida-Texas game (noon ET, ABC) feels like. Florida is the man with the rope around his neck. Texas is the jukebox about to be tossed overboard in waters inhabited by great white sharks several miles from the nearest beach. The Gators (4-2, 2-2 SEC) have plunged from college football's surprise darlings to here we go again thanks to a defense that seems bent on channeling its inner Todd Grantham and an offensive line that evokes memories of batters who faced Sandy Koufax in his prime. Whiff! Texas (4-1, 1-1 SEC), meanwhile, is the jukebox. The seventh-ranked Longhorns have an offense that desperately needs to get well and who better than the worst defense in the SEC to have the same healing properties of a few days soaking in the hot springs at the Arenal volcano in Costa Rica. Texas also has a defense coordinated by Will Muschamp, who remembers all too well being dumped by the Gators in 2014 when he was the head coach. The multiple millions of buyout money have not soothed that wound.

Full story: gatorbaitmedia.com/post/the-soothsayer-texas-big-unless-the-uf-defense-finds-an-exorcist

EDDIE GILLEY

SO YOU'RE SAYING THERE'S A CHANCE!?

BY EDDIE GILLEY Oct. 15, 2026



Photo by Chris Spears, GatorBait Media

Well, the low scoring Longhorns have their struggles, too.

I wrote earlier in the week about the similarities of the stats between UF and UM last weekend in every category but the one that matters. Facing the Texas Longhorns on the road in Austin is a tough task for a team that hasn't played well in the last two weeks.

The Gators hit the road as a 10.5-point underdog. Is there anything that points to a possible Gator victory?

The Gators will face the #3 total defense in the SEC in the Will Muschamp led Texas defense. They are ranked either third or fourth in the conference in every category. They are the #13 ranked defense in college football.

That task is a daunting task by itself. Throw in the possibility of having Tramell Jones Jr. making his first road SEC start and the hill gets a little higher.

Add in the uncertainty of Vernell Brown III and the health of Eric Singleton and the road gets even more steep.

The offense couldn't gain any traction on the road in Columbia, Mo. and didn't do much better against the guys from Columbia e

Full story: gatorbaitmedia.com/post/so-you-re-saying-there-s-a-chance-1

GAME WEEK

REPORT: AARON PHILO'S STATUS UNCERTAIN FOR FLORIDA'S TRIP TO TEXAS

BY BRENDEN MARTIN Oct. 14, 2026



Photo by Chris Spears, GatorBait Media

Aaron Philo was limited at practice Wednesday, according to On3. Tramell Jones Jr. would be next in line if Philo cannot play.

Aaron Philo runs against Auburn on Sept. 19, 2026. Archival photo by Chris Spears, GatorBait Media.

GAINESVILLE - Florida's trip to Texas now includes a question about whether Aaron Philo will be available to run the offense Saturday.

On3 reported Wednesday, citing GatorsOnline reporter Zach Abolverdi, that Philo threw at practice but was limited by an injury. His availability for the game is uncertain, according to that report.

Tramell Jones Jr. would be next in line if Philo cannot play. The report does not establish that Philo has been ruled out, and an injury-driven change would be different from a decision to replace him as Florida's starter.

The Gators, 4-2 overall and 2-2 in the SEC, visit No. 7 Texas on Saturday, Oct. 17. Kickoff in Austin is noon ET on ABC.

Philo completed 21 of 28 passes for 227 yards, one touchdown and one interception in Florida's 38-19 loss to South Carolina last Saturday. Jones entered in the fourth quarter and finished 6 of 8 for 40 yards with an interception.

Full story: gatorbaitmedia.com/post/report-aaron-philo-s-status-uncertain-for-florida-s-trip-to-texas

FRANZ BEARD · THOUGHTS OF THE DAY

THOUGHTS OF THE DAY: MUSCHAMP, MANNING AND THE TRIP TO TEXAS

BY FRANZ BEARD Oct. 14, 2026



GatorBait Media illustration

A few thoughts to jump start your Wednesday morning:

It isn't just the Florida Gators (4-2, 2-2 SEC) against the No. 7 Texas Longhorns (4-1, 1-1 SEC) Saturday in Austin (noon ET, 11 a.m. CT, ABC). It is the Gators against ghosts of the past.

On the Texas sideline coaching up the defense will be coordinator Will Muschamp, the same guy who dialed up the defense at Auburn to hand the Gators their only loss on their way to a national championship in 2006. He was Florida's head coach from 2011-14, coaching some fabulous defenses and leaving behind NFL-quality talent that helped Jim McElwain win successive SEC East titles. Success faded as that talent moved on to the NFL.

And then there is Arch Manning, grandson of Archie, nephew of Peyton and Eli. Given the bloodlines, perhaps no high school quarterback has ever arrived in college with as much hype. He's 16-4 as a starting quarterback, with 5,254 career passing yards, 45 touchdown passes and 14 interceptions, plus a 6-2 record against ranked teams. But no one in the country gets more criticism if the Longhorns lose a game.

Muschamp's Texas defense is formidable. In his return to Texas as defensive coordinator, he obviously hasn't lost his touch. Muschamp was on Georgia's staff for its back-to-back national championships in 2021 and 2022. Texas has given up 601 yards in its last three games, just 41 more than Missouri had in its 45-17 beatdown of the Gators. Since halftime of the Longhorns' win over then-No. 1 Ohio State, Texas has allowed two offensive touchdowns in 14 quarters, one on a short field after a shanked punt. The Longhorns left Knoxville with 10 sacks, 5.5 by Colin Simmons after a statistical correction. Simmons leads the nation with 9.5 sacks this season.

Full story: gatorbaitmedia.com/post/thoughts-of-the-day-october-14-2026

FRANZ BEARD

PHILO IS THE FLORIDA QUARTERBACK, AT LEAST FOR NOW

BY FRANZ BEARD Oct. 13, 2026



Photo by Chris Spears, GatorBait Media

Because it is universally described as the single most important position in all of team sports, when it comes to football fingers immediately point to the quarterback whenever things go south, which they have the last two weeks for the Florida Gators (4-2, 2-2 SEC). Aaron Philo, whose numbers were just a shade under brilliant in Florida's 4-0 September have taken a serious plunge in losses to Missouri and South Carolina. In the four wins, Philo was 76-104 passing, good for 1,091 yards (10.49 yards per attempt) and eight touchdowns. Two of his three interceptions were deflections by a wide receiver who should have caught the football. In the losses, Philo is 53-75 for 550 yards (7.33 yards per attempt), three touchdowns and two picks.

The yards per pass attempt is the single most revealing stat in football and a three yards per attempt differential between games one through four and the last two says plenty about an offense that scored more than 40 points each ga/me in September to one that has produced a combined 36 points in October. The Gators were a top five offense in September, averaging more than 523 yards per game, but that plunged significantly starting with Missouri (325 yards) and got only slightly better against South Carolina (387).

Full story: gatorbaitmedia.com/post/philo-is-the-florida-quarterback-at-least-for-now

BUDDY MARTIN

BUDDY BLOG: A GATOR ASS-WHIPPING, WITH BOWL PROJECTIONS IN THE ASHES

BY BUDDY MARTIN Oct. 13, 2026



Photo by Chris Spears, GatorBait Media

Florida's sideline during the South Carolina game at Ben Hill Griffin Stadium on Oct. 10, 2026.

Trying to find two more wins is going to take patience and ibuprofen

It wasn't the Grim Reaper. He generally has the courtesy to finish the job. South Carolina merely left Florida lying there with six games remaining and a fan base wondering whether the season came with a refund policy.

This was a good old-fashioned ass-whipping, delivered on a particularly bad Saturday for the Gators to discover they were the ones furnishing the ass.

A punch in the mouth? Too charitable. A punch in the mouth suggests you might still be standing afterward, perhaps considering a response.

This was a right cross, an uppercut, a gut punch and a kick in the family jewels. Apparently, South Carolina had purchased the deluxe package.

For the boxing crowd, think jab–cross–left hook. The classic 1–2–3: two straight shots followed by a hook that makes you reconsider your recreational interests.

Checkers, perhaps? Something with a chair.

Or the right cross–left hook–right cross, which dispenses with introductions and gets directly to the damage. Then the uppercut–left hook: one coming up, the other coming around, neither interested in your preseason expectations.

Full story: gatorbaitmedia.com/post/buddy-blog-a-gator-ass-whipping-with-bowl-projections-in-the-ashes

FRANZ BEARD

TEXAS OPENS AS A 10-POINT FAVORITE AGAINST FLORIDA

BY FRANZ BEARD Oct. 12, 2026



GatorBait Media illustration

Combine a September that far exceeded everyone's expectations with the last two weekends and you have a plot straight out of a Roadrunner cartoon. You know how it goes.

Wile E. Coyote orders a rocket from Acme, mounts it and lights a fuse in order to catch up with the Roadrunner. The Roadrunner stops at the edge of a canyon, Wile goes flying by and a thousand feet above the canyon floor, the rocket fizzles out. Wile and the rocket fall to the bottom of the canyon with a loud crash.

Isn't that what Florida's 4-0 September and October's 0-2 at the hands of Missouri and South Carolina feels like? The rocket has fizzled out and unless Jon Sumrall and his staff can reignite it, there will be a crash on a canyon floor. This is when we find out what the Gators are made of.

Adversity has struck not once, but twice and on successive weekends to boot.

Sumrall saw it coming, which is why he warned after the Ole Miss win, "You have to humble yourself or you will be humbled." The Gators have been humbled now and how they respond will dictate the last six weeks of the regular season.

Full story: gatorbaitmedia.com/post/texas-opens-as-a-10-point-favorite-against-florida

EDDIE GILLEY

NUMBERS DON'T LIE

BY EDDIE GILLEY Oct. 12, 2026



Photo by Chris Spears, GatorBait Media

Numbers don't lie except when they do! When we got into the media room after the game on Saturday, the staff handed us a stat sheet. I couldn't believe the numbers could be accurate. That wasn't the game I had just watched with my eyes. It couldn't have been that game. Let me show you what I mean.

First downs: South Carolina 22, Florida 20

Rushing yards: South Carolina 114, Florida 120

Passing yards: South Carolina 279, Florida 267

Total yards: South Carolina 393, Florida 387

Full story: gatorbaitmedia.com/post/numbers-don-t-lie

Do those numbers look like they belong to a 38-19 score?

What in the world happened to make this game a lopsided affair that ended in a statistical draw? The biggest number might be the number 3, as in 3 Gator turnovers. Philo fumbled on a drive deep in the Gamecocks' end of the field to stop one drive. The interception from Philo late in the second quarter gave South Carolina a short field and a missed opportunity to stop them on third down led to a touchdown for SC. A missed fourth down in the fourth quarter gave them another short field that led to a quick touchdown for the visitors. The interception thrown by Jones was also in the SC end of the field although by that time the game was really over.

BUDDY MARTIN

AN ANATOMY OF TOTAL GATOR COLLAPSE: A SWAMP STREWN WITH BROKEN DREAMS

BY BUDDY MARTIN Oct. 12, 2026



Photo by Chris Spears, GatorBait Media

Not even the passion of the HBC could help. (Chris Spears photo)

By Buddy Martin

Two weeks ago, Florida was unbeaten, ranked No. 8 and looking like a football team that had discovered something. An identity. A formula. Maybe even a future.

Now the Gators have disappeared from both the AP Top 25 and the Coaches Poll, and the rankings might be the least troubling thing that has vanished.

The running game is missing. The offensive imagination seems to have gone with it. The defense has become accommodating. And those offensive and defensive lines we were praising as the foundation of this team? Apparently, the foundation needs inspecting.

Missouri, 45-17. South Carolina, 38-19. Right before God, country and Steve Spurrier. At his Monday presser, Jon Sumrall looked composed after a fiery morning practice, somewhat revitalized and gritty while still looking for answers.

Whatever composure that Sumrall appeared to have lost – some of you were going by his body language – he had gotten back by his press conference on Monday and he made it very clear: nobody has been trying to tame him or change his sometimes salty language. He was scoffing at the notion and doubled down on his vow to never change his personality.

Full story: gatorbaitmedia.com/post/an-anatomy-of-total-gator-collapse-a-swamp-strewn-with-broken-dreams

BEST SHOTS

From South Carolina 38, Florida 19 · Photo by Chris Spears, GatorBait Media



Out of the tunnel



Stockton, 59 yards



Albert leads the way



Sumrall walks out



Eyes forward

MASTHEAD

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PREGAME DESK, GRAPHICS AND PRODUCTION

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Next up: an open date, then Georgia in Atlanta on Oct. 31.

GatorBait Magazine, Friday Pregame Edition, Friday, Oct. 16, 2026. Independent Florida Gators coverage. ESPN game summary (event 401856724), scoreboard, team statistics, rosters and AP Top 25 (Week 7), DraftKings line via ESPN pickcenter, all pulled Oct. 15, 2026 (about 7 p.m. ET); NWS Austin/San Antonio forecast issued Oct. 15; FloridaGators.com series history and schedule; TexasLonghorns.com game center. The line and forecast can move before Saturday. Published by GatorBait Media, www.gatorbaitmedia.com.